

Incident Alert 0026. TLP Green.		Date	Breakout Scale
Title	EU – News aggregators give access to sanctioned Russian media	26/08/2024	3

Summary

- Ground News, Dailyhunt, Inoreader, Muck Rack and Google Chrome News tab (5 out of 13 surveyed news aggregators) provide direct access to RT and Sputnik content. Whether by providing the article on the platform or linking to still active mirror websites of the sanctioned media.
- This is a method for circumventing EU sanctions as it makes Russian sanctioned media available in the EU.
- [Council Regulation No 269/2014](#) prohibits hosting content from these channels or making them available to EU audiences on any platforms, as clarified in [Commission guidance](#) updated mid-May 2024.

Incident

As of August 13, the news aggregators Ground News, Dailyhunt, Inoreader, Muck Rack (and Google Chrome News tab to a lesser degree), provide access to the latest RT and Sputnik content. Groundnews, Inoreader and Muck Rack cover both outlets, while Dailyhunt only features RT and Google News tab only Sputnik.

Over the past three months, Groundnews aggregated 2974 Sputnik articles ([1](#)) and 4813 RT articles([2](#)). Both sources are labelled as RU-affiliated. Groundnews does not host articles directly on the platform. Rather, it redirects via links to the media websites. Sputnik's articles are accessible via an accessible mirror website ([3](#)). RT headlines are available on Groundnews ([4](#)), but full articles are not accessible, as no mirror account can be found. Groundnews does not seem to work through RSS.

On Muck Rack, RT ([5](#)) and Sputnik ([6](#), [7](#)) have their own media outlet pages. Muck Rack provides snippets of the articles and then redirects to external mirror websites ([8](#)). As such, RT full articles are not available. Sputnik pages redirect to two functioning mirror websites ([9](#), [10](#)).

Inoreader is an RSS-based aggregator, that has the highest number of feeds spreading RT and Sputnik's content: 4 official Sputnik "feeds" ([11](#), [12](#), [13](#), [14](#)) and 16 RT's ([15](#), [16](#), [17](#), [18](#), [19](#), [20](#), [21](#), [22](#), [23](#), [24](#), [25](#), [26](#), [27](#), [28](#), [29](#), [30](#)). For Sputnik, Inoreader hosts short snippets of the articles on the platform, redirecting to the full articles in 4 mirror websites ([31](#), [32](#), [33](#), [34](#)). The RT's mirror websites linked to Inoreader have been suspended. However, Inoreader copy-paste the entire text of the RT articles to its platform ([35](#)). Full texts are provided for all articles of 12 of the feeds and short snippets for 4 of the feeds.

Dailyhunt is an automatic aggregator which hosts RT articles. Dailyhunt received funding from the Chinese TikTok owner Bytedance, who's CEO also has a seat on the board of Dailyhunt ([36](#)). The RT articles are fully hosted by the platform and accessible in Europe ([37](#)). Sputnik is not present.

The Google News app does not feature RT and Sputnik content. However, the "News" tab of the Google Browser redirects to Sputnik's content ([38](#)).

This alert suggests that media aggregator apps, especially if based on RSS, may facilitate access to sanctioned media by aggregating normally harder-to-find mirror websites in one place. Through the aggregators, 5 accessible mirror websites were identified ([RT Spanish](#), [Sputnik Globe](#), [Sputnik News Africa](#), [Sputnik Mundo](#), [Sputnik Kirgystan](#)).

This is one in a series of five on Russian sanctions circumvention and will be included in a future public report.

Narrative

Not applicable

Impact

Only the reach of Muck Rack, Inoreader and Daily Hunt could be verified. According to the sharing figures of Muck Rack (reliability unknown), both RT and Sputnik's posts have all 0 or very few shares. Inoreader totals 1004

followers for the RT feeds and 3625 for Sputnik's. Daily Hunt's RT account has 5.7k followers. This is a limited reach, but the content made available could be copy pasted in other platforms. More research would be needed.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [Facilitate State Propaganda](#) – amplifying sanctioned Russian state media content.

[Bypass Content Blocking](#) – The aggregators are hosting the content and sharing them on their websites.

Recommendations

- Action taken: Emails sent to mentioned platforms and alerts sent to EU governments.
- Notify the EU Sanctions Envoy of the news aggregators companies violation of EU sanctions.
- The EU to coordinate an awareness raising campaign to companies potentially affected by the sanctions.
- Further investigate other platforms.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
N/A	Sanctions, Russia	Link	Claudia De Sessa (opinion of author are her own and does not reflect her official employer). Saman Nazari (editor), Alliance4Europe .	Articles	Google, Muck Rack, Inkl, Flipboard, Curio, Apple news, Inoreader, Dailyhunt, Bundle, Aggregator News, RSS Reader, Ground News